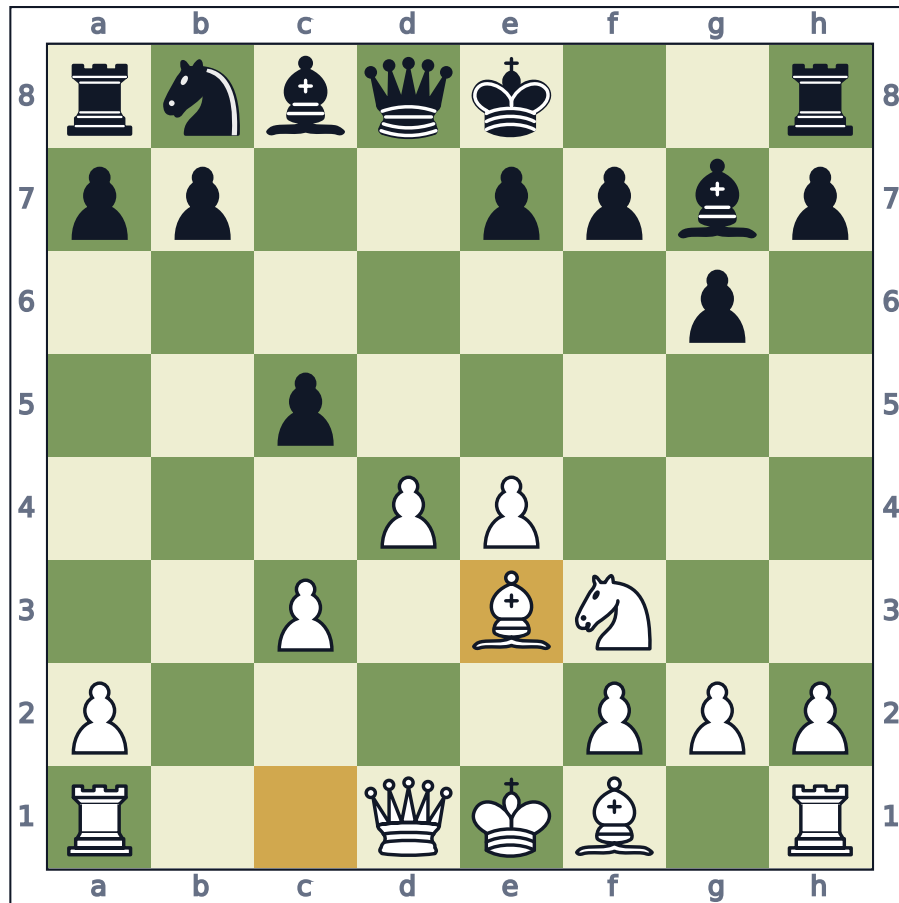


Grunfeld Defense

A ground-up visual course for practical play



Core route position - gold marks the last move

BOTH SIDES

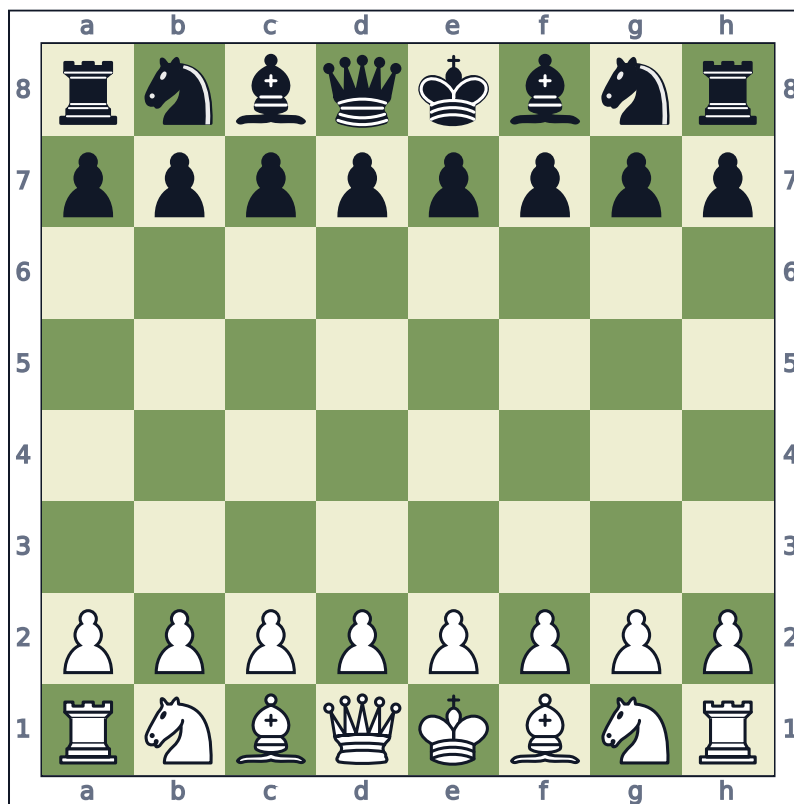
OPENING IDENTITY

Black lets White build a broad center, then attacks it immediately from a distance.

ORIENTATION

Ground zero: read the board and the moves

White starts from ranks 1-2; Black starts from ranks 7-8. Files run a through h. Each lesson highlights the last move in gold so your eyes connect notation to the board.



Starting position - White to move

HOW ALGEBRAIC NOTATION WORKS

Nf3 means a knight moves to f3. B means bishop, R rook, Q queen, K king; pawns use only the destination square. An x means capture, + means check, and O-O means kingside castling.

YOUR FIRST ANCHOR

Say the first moves aloud, then point to every destination square:

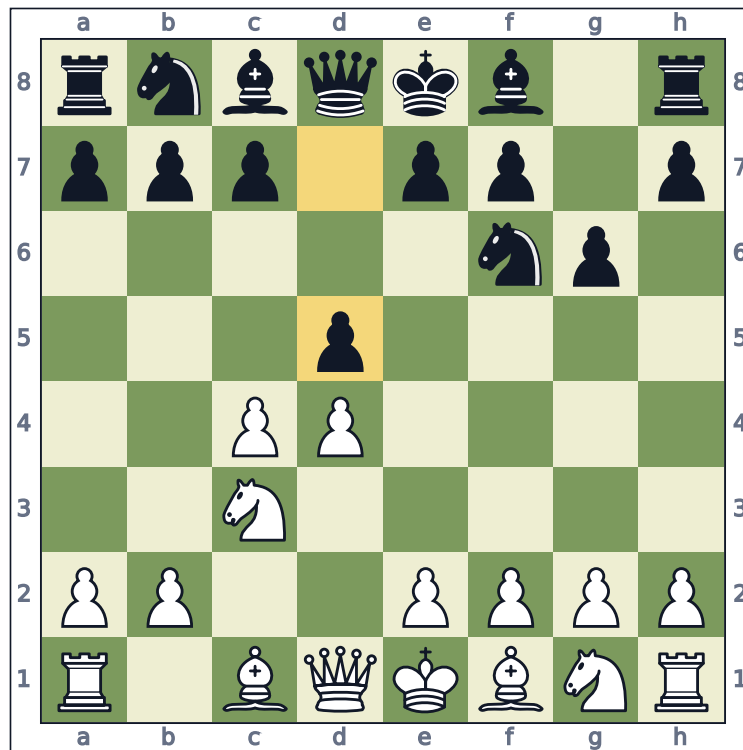
1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5

Course promise: Build the center, then prove it can survive pressure.

MOVES 1-3

Lesson 1: the first conversation

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5



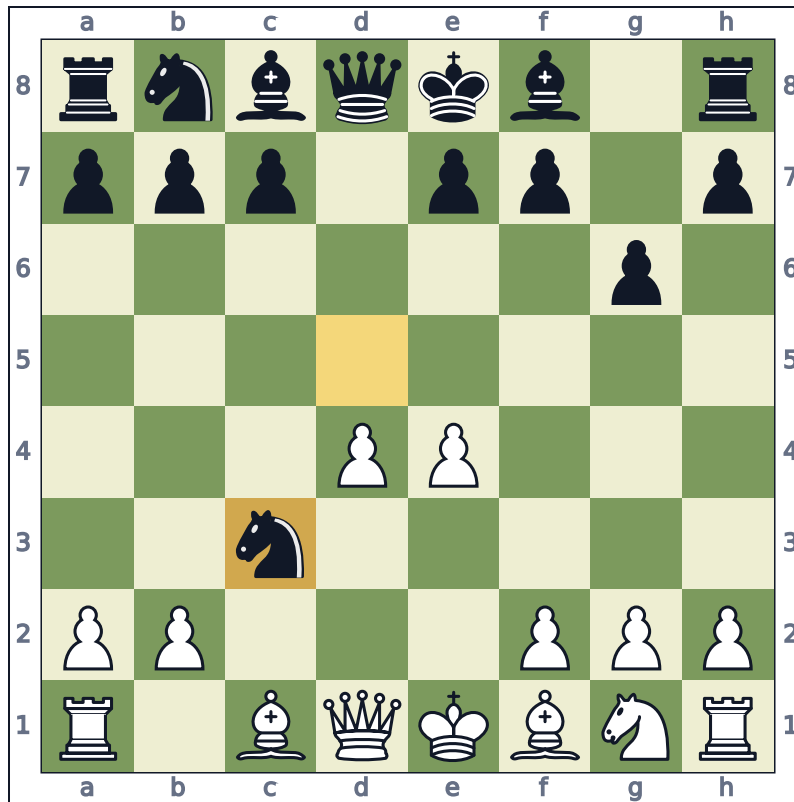
After 3. Nc3 d5

- 1. d4 - Claims or challenges central space and opens a line for a piece.
- 1... Nf6 - Develops a knight toward the center and increases control of key central squares.
- 2. c4 - Creates a lever against the center or supports a coming break.
- 2... g6 - Gains wing space, but also changes squares that can no longer be protected by this pawn.
- 3. Nc3 - Develops a knight toward the center and increases control of key central squares.
- 3... d5 - Claims or challenges central space and opens a line for a piece.

DEVELOPMENT

Lesson 2: build the core position

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5 4. cxd5 Nxd5 5. e4 Nxc3



White to move

WHAT THE PIECES ARE BUILDING

Black lets White build a broad center, then attacks it immediately from a distance.

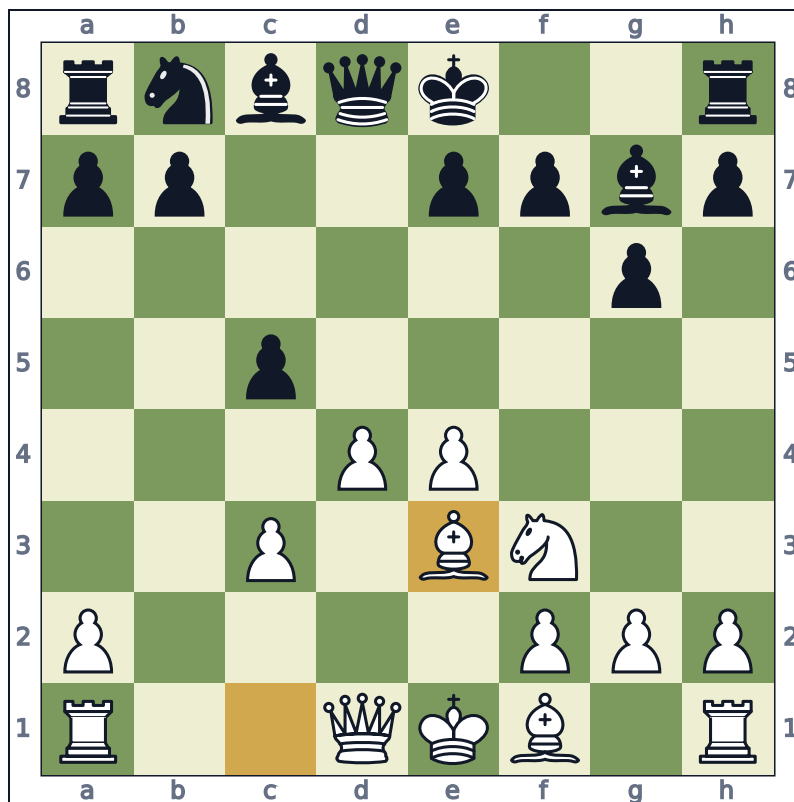
BEGINNER CHECKPOINT

Before copying the next move, ask: Is my king safe? Which piece is still at home? What changed in the center? Which pawn break is each side preparing?

CORE LINE

Lesson 3: complete the main route

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5 4. cxd5 Nxd5 5. e4 Nxc3 6. bxc3 Bg7 7. Nf3 c5 8. Be3



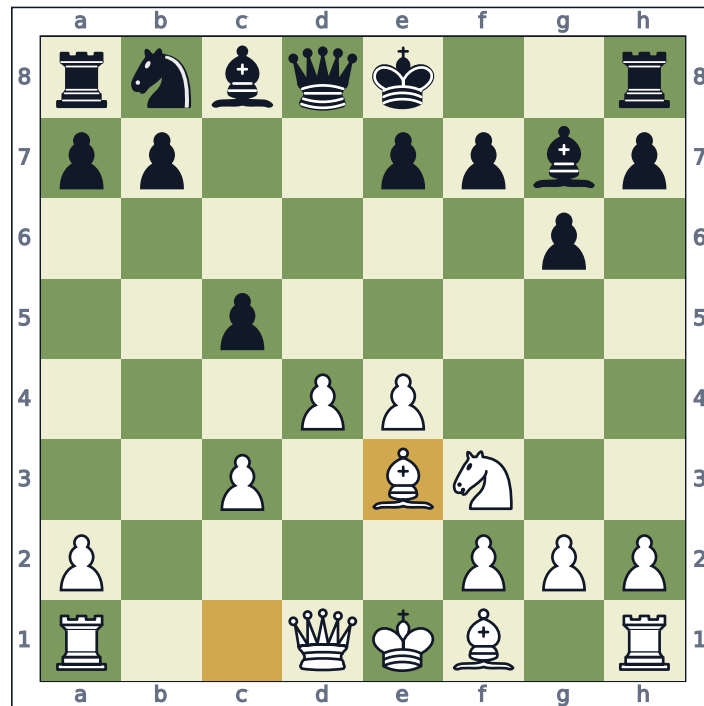
Core position - now plans matter more than memorized moves

DO NOT MEMORIZE BLINDLY

The route is a model, not a forced script. Its job is to teach this relationship: Black lets White build a broad center, then attacks it immediately from a distance. If the opponent deviates, preserve the same priorities until a concrete tactic changes them.

UNDERSTANDING

The position map: plans for both sides



Read plans from the pawn structure, not from the opening name

WHITE'S PLAN

Use the center to gain space and activity while keeping its base defended.

BLACK'S PLAN

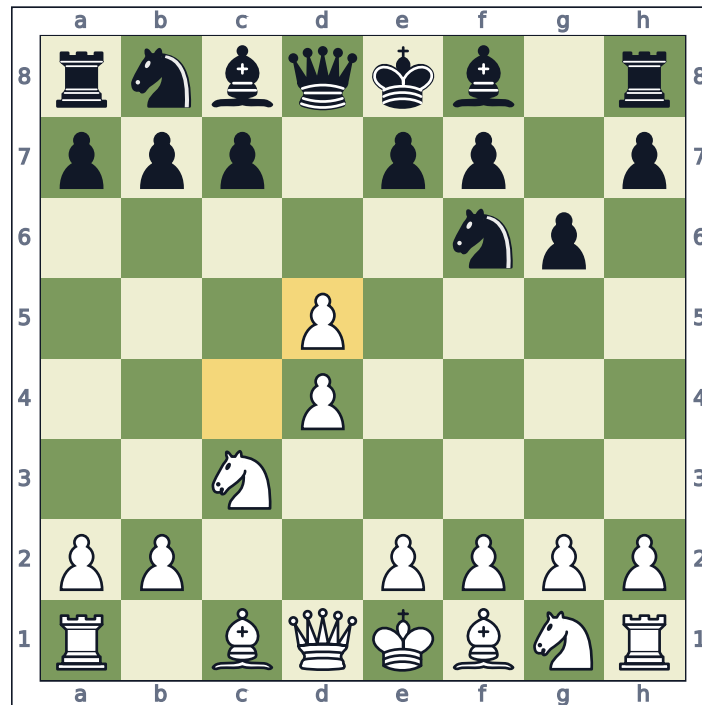
Pressure d4 with the g7-bishop, c5, and piece activity; trade pieces that support the center.

THE LEVER TO REMEMBER

...c5 is the main strike; ...e5 may add a second challenge.

CALCULATION

Tactical literacy: what can suddenly change



Pause here - Black to move

THEME

The d4-pawn can be overloaded because it supports e5 ideas and blocks the bishop diagonal.

COMMON BEGINNER ERROR

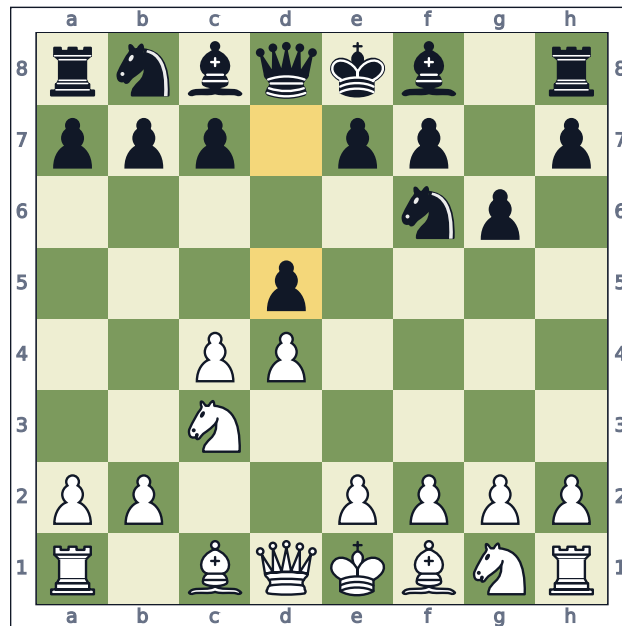
For White, believing a large center maintains itself; for Black, attacking it without development.

THREE-SECOND SAFETY SCAN

1. Checks against both kings. 2. Captures in the center. 3. Threats against loose or pinned pieces.

ADAPTATION

Decision tree: when the opponent leaves the route



A branch point - principles are your map

1. If the center stays fluid

Finish development and keep the opening identity in view: Black lets White build a broad center, then attacks it immediately from a distance.

2. If the center closes

Use the pawn-chain direction. Attack the base before making wing moves that cannot be supported.

3. If the center opens

Prioritize king safety, active pieces, and checks or captures before slow pawn moves.

4. If nothing is forced

Return to the planned lever: ...c5 is the main strike; ...e5 may add a second challenge.

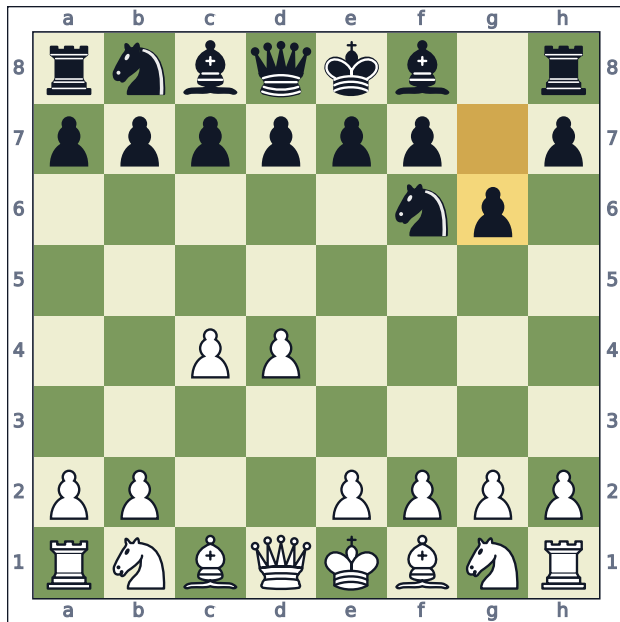
MEMORY SENTENCE

Build the center, then prove it can survive pressure.

ACTIVE RECALL

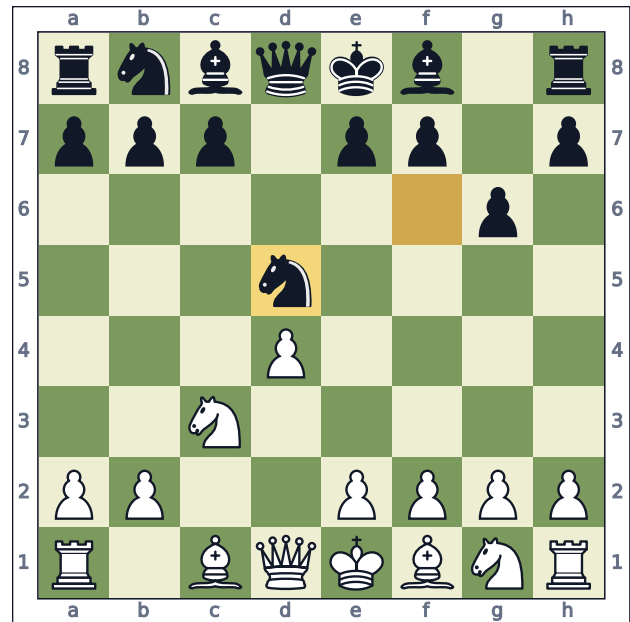
Recall test: answer before you turn the page

POSITION A



White to move

POSITION B



White to move

- A1. What is the next route move for White?
- A2. What opening problem does that move solve?
- B1. What is the next route move for White?
- B2. Name one plan for White and one plan for Black.
- C. State the thematic pawn break without looking back.

SCORING

5/5: replay from memory. 3-4/5: review Lessons 3 and 6. 0-2/5: return to Lesson 1 and rebuild the route slowly.

RETENTION

Answer key and a 14-day practice loop

POSITION A

Next route move: Nc3. Explain it using development, center, king safety, or a direct tactical need.

POSITION B

Next route move: e4. Then compare the position with the final core board.

PLAN AND BREAK ANSWERS

White: Use the center to gain space and activity while keeping its base defended. Black: Pressure d4 with the g7-bishop, c5, and piece activity; trade pieces that support the center. Lever: ...c5 is the main strike; ...e5 may add a second challenge.

14-DAY LOOP

- Days 1-2: replay the first three moves from both sides and name each move's job.
- Days 3-4: build the core position from memory; correct the first error, then restart.
- Days 5-6: say White's plan, Black's plan, and the pawn break without a board.
- Day 7: take the recall test. Record the score; do not count lucky guesses.
- Days 8-10: play three slow practice games, starting from the core position if possible.
- Days 11-13: review only mistakes and deviations that actually occurred in your games.
- Day 14: retake the test and write a one-sentence opening rule in your own words.